

Have a Heart! Protect yours naturally

Many of the requests for health advice I get from my patients involve taking care of their heart – what can they do to prevent or improve heart ailments? I'm always pleased when a patient wants to take a pro-active role in their heart health as it is one of the most important things one can do.

What's causing our Heart Disease?

There are many heart conditions that are structurally related. For instance some people are born with defective valves or thickening/enlargement of heart muscles. Heart disorders can also be caused by infections from bacteria or viruses. Irregular heartbeat is also a common condition.

However, poor lifestyle behaviors account for the majority of heart diseases.

What to Ask Your Doctor?

For a lot of people, the first time they find out they have heart disease is in the emergency room with chest pain, or worse, a heart attack! Rather than wait for the worst, learn to be pro-active now. Some blood tests are available to provide you with a clearer picture of your current heart health. I recommend getting a baseline level of these heart-health markers before you start any heart-health improvement program to see what areas you need to improve.

Homocysteine – Can damage arterial walls and cause dangerous blood clots. **C-reactive protein, cardiac (CRP)** – Elevated CRP raises risk of heart attack threefold. **HDL cholesterol** – “good” cholesterol. Optimal level should be higher than 60. **LDL cholesterol** – “bad” cholesterol. Optimal level should aim at 100 or less. **Total cholesterol** – Level should be around 200. Too low cholesterol can cause hormone-building problems for both men (testosterone) and women (estrogen).

Heal and Protect Your Heart Naturally

The good news is that you can improve your heart health naturally. The biggest offenders to a healthy heart are behaviors you may be engaging in every day and by modifying some of these behaviors, and getting rid of others, you can gain better heart health.

Some beneficial heart-healthy changes that I recommend to my patients are:

Eat less saturated fats, cut red meat to twice a week and limit total SFs to 7% of total calories. Limit trans fats as these can raise LDL (bad) and lower HDL (good) cholesterol. Add Plant proteins – all types of beans, peas, nuts, are excellent sources of 0 cholesterol, low fat, and high B vitamin plant proteins. Add heart-healthy nutrients – Omega-3 fish oil and Omega-6 oils like olive and safflower oil; B vitamins, especially B3, B6 and B12. Add through food sources or supplements. Eat more fruits and vegetables.

Exercise: A simple 30 minute walk at least 3 times a week can help your heart stay strong and raise HDL levels.

Smoking: Smoking is one of the worst things you can do for your health. It severely damages your heart and lungs which work together to keep you alive. If you quit smoke, the heart/lung benefit is immediate.

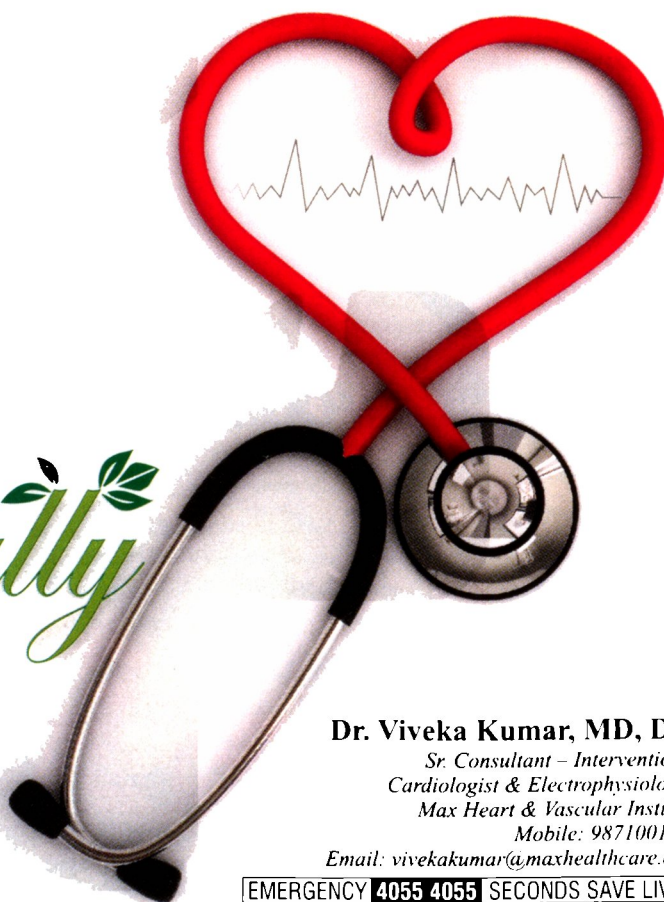
Alcohol: Heavy alcohol consumption of hard liquor causes increased triglycerides, weakens pumping capacity of the heart and decreases your oxygen capacity. A glass of red wine or beer a day, however, actually can be beneficial to your heart as they contain antioxidants and phytonutrients that help your heart.

Drugs: Both recreational and prescription drugs have side effects that can be heart damaging. Talk to your doctor about the possible side effects of your prescription drugs to your heart. If you engage in recreational drugs, like smoking, no modifications will lessen the effects of these.

Start by adding one of the above mentioned changes every couple of weeks and by the end of three months, I guarantee your heart will be on the way to optimal health! Indulge in some sugar-free-dark chocolate; it contains powerful antioxidants and minerals that are actually good for your heart!



*Protect
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